

CHRONOLOGICAL / NON-CHRON.

Telling events in order, or out of order



1 What is it?

Chronological / Non-Chronological Structure

Chronological structure tells events **in the order they happened**. Non-chronological structure deliberately **jumps around in time** — using flashbacks, flash-forwards, or multiple timelines.

1, 2, 3... vs 3, 1, 2...

2 See it in action

Chronological

A story told simply from morning to night, in the order events occurred.

Non-chronological

A novel opens with the ending, then jumps back to explain how it happened.

Multiple timelines

Chapters alternate between "Now" and "Ten Years Ago" throughout the book.

Fragmented structure

Short, out-of-order scenes mirror a character's confused or traumatic memory.



Mfalme says...

Before analysing anything else, try to **map out the real order** events actually happened in — then compare that to the order the writer chose to tell them. The gap between the two is where the analysis lives.

FUN FACT

Christopher Nolan's film "Memento" tells its story almost entirely backwards — mirroring its character's own broken memory.

3 Why writers use it

Chronological / Non-Chronological Structure help writers:

a chronological structure builds clear, steady suspense, while a non-chronological one can create mystery, dramatic irony, or mirror how memory actually works — jumping around rather than moving in a straight line.

Choosing a non-chronological structure is a huge, deliberate decision — it forces the reader to actively piece together the timeline themselves, which increases engagement and tension.

4 Where you'll spot it

Detective & mystery fiction

Often opens with a crime's aftermath, then moves backward to reveal how it happened.

Memoir & trauma narratives

Non-chronological, fragmented structure can realistically mirror how difficult memories surface out of order.



Watch out!

Don't assume non-chronological structure is automatically "better" or more sophisticated — always explain WHY that specific structural choice suits THIS particular story's theme or effect.



Look here!

Ask what a **non-chronological jump** achieves that telling the story in order couldn't — usually mystery, irony, or a link between past and present.

5 Quick recap

Chronological = in order

Non-chronological = jumps in time

Shapes suspense and understanding



You got this!

Try retelling a familiar story completely out of order, starting with the end — notice how the feeling changes.